

Apple's doing it right

In the wake of the Nov 2008 Mumbai terror attacks, most people, in a knee-jerk reaction, were willing to make sweeping compromises to their digital privacy. "Let Big Brother watch" was the overarching sentiment during those tumultuous times. In fact, you might've read that very line in these pages.

I don't blame the extreme reactions. A lot of people in the world are willing to forego their civil liberties in the wake of such calamities. The ripples of such compromises can be felt even today, long after the 9/11 attacks in the US; and I'm not even talking about the infamous Patriot Act. I'm talking about the more recent absurd FBI directive calling upon Apple to put in an encryption backdoor on its iPhones.

Being readers of Digit you most likely already know about the tough stance that Apple CEO Tim Cook has taken on the matter, so I'll just skim through the important bits for the benefit of those who came in late.

The FBI wants Apple to build a tool that'll be used to access a locked iPhone, which belonged to one of the San Bernardino shooters. Ostensibly, the tool will only be used to gain access to just that phone. Yeah right! Do they really expect us to believe that? What's more unbelievable is that the mighty US Government with all its billions in resources can't get access to a measly little iPhone. There's obviously more to it than meets the eye.

Apple on its part contends that it's a slippery slope both from the point of view of setting up a disastrous legal precedent and also from the perspective of deliberately devolving security protocols that took them years to develop. By building something that allows authorised access to an encrypted system, Apple will literally open the door to cyber criminals.

Brilliant nut job and self proclaimed "cyber-security legend" John McAfee has also weighed in on the debate. In his inimitable style, he's offered to break the encryption on the iPhone in question for free. Of course, he goes on to cite various reasons for why the FBI doesn't have the technical chops to get into the iPhone. I think he's just half joking because even he knows it's not really about this particular phone. There's a very interesting Reddit thread where people who presumably know their shit are talking about methods at the chip level that could circumvent the cryptoprocessor by installing custom hardware that'll power off the device

after each failed attempt. After that, it's a simple matter of brute forcing (<http://dgit.in/rddithack>). Now I don't claim to know hacking nearly enough to verify the claim but I know enough to know that there are some really smart people out there.

When I said earlier that there's more at play here than meets the eye, this is precisely what I meant - it's not about this one San Bernardino iPhone at all! Instead it's about the US government's attempt at getting its tentacles into encrypted systems. It wants to make a norm out of what should be an exception. It wants to make hacking into "a process" - something any halfwit with a terminal would be able to do eventually, if this backdoor tool is actually made.

Apple and Tim Cook certainly deserve all the kudos for sticking it to the feds. But this does raise some important questions: If Apple is only standing up now, what have they and other tech companies been agreeing to before this? Apart from valid warrants requesting simpler things such as call records as evidence for example.

Also when we Indians use products of big American companies, what are our rights as non US citizens? Do we even have any? What about similar deals between intelligence/investigation agencies within our borders? Could the Indian govt too have struck backroom deals for installing such backdoors into hardware that we use here? Afterall, our market is large enough to make any tech giant bend over backwards in order to get entry to it.

These might seem like first world problems right now, but if history is anything to go by, they'll become real problems here soon enough. If you have any doubts about the consequences this can lead to, here's a picture that says it better than a thousand words: <http://dgit.in/bkdoorconsq>. For copyright reasons I couldn't print it but do have a look and let me know your thoughts. You know how to reach me. 



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